

Yu Zhang

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Labour migration and urban precarity, informal economy and urban governance, housing and livelihoods, policy engagement and community-based research, ethnography, situated and embodied knowledge, qualitative and mixed methods

EDUCATION

Universiteit van Amsterdam

Amsterdam, Netherlands

Master of Science in Social Sciences (research)

Sep 2023 — Jul 2025

- GPA: 7.19/10 (120 EC); Thesis grade: 8/10
- Thesis: “Let the Wild In”: Fermentation, Cleanliness, and Competitive Collaboration in a Multispecies Brewery
- Relevant courses: Research Skills: Ethnography and Beyond; Working with Fieldwork Data; The Anthropology of the Future; Race, Sex and Postcolonial STS; Qualitative Research Design and Fieldwork Proposal; Epistemology, Quality and Ethics in Social Sciences Research, Policy Oriented Research

Xi'an Jiaotong-Liverpool University & University of Liverpool (Dual Degree)

Suzhou, China

Bachelor of Arts in Media and Communication Studies

Sep 2019 — Jun 2023

- Upper Second Class Honours (2:1); weighted average 62% (180 EC)
- Relevant courses: Representation, Diversity and Identity; Social Network Analysis; Qualitative Research Methods; Quantitative Research Methods; Artificial Intelligence and Big Data in Society

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Independent Thesis Research, "Let the Wild In": Fermentation, Cleanliness, and Competitive Collaboration in a Multispecies Brewery

June 2024 — May 2025

Universiteit van Amsterdam

Supervised by Dr Rebeca Ibáñez Martín

Amsterdam, Netherlands & Yunnan, China

- Conducted three months of ethnographic fieldwork in Yunnan, China; built field access across linguistic and ethnic boundaries through sustained community embedding and reflexive positionality work
- Developed “competitive collaboration” as an original analytic framework describing how working relationships are maintained not through consensus but through continuous, friction-filled adjustment between actors with unequal power navigating shared spaces under conditions of uncertainty
- Key words: workplace ethnography, participant observation, situated and embodied knowledge, feminist epistemology, power asymmetry, everyday practice, multispecies ethnography

Research Fellow, From the Street to the Night Market: Informal Economy and the Regulation of Street Vending in Suzhou City of China

Jun 2022 — Sep 2022

Xi'an Jiaotong-Liverpool University

Supervised by Dr Lefeng Lin

Suzhou, China

- Fully funded by University Summer Undergraduate Research Fellowship
- Conducted a three-month qualitative fieldwork study with internal labour migrants working as informal street vendors navigating intersecting livelihood and spatial precarity; participants included men and women across different age groups who had migrated from less-developed regions to sustain their livelihoods in the urban informal economy during the COVID-19 lockdown
- Built field access through direct community embedding: became a regular customer and gradually entered vendors' everyday networks; navigated an initial trust barrier when a community gatekeeper feared research would trigger governmental repression of their trade, resolving this through transparent communication of the research's policy orientation
- Translated fieldwork findings into policy recommendations submitted to a district government think tank
- Directed and edited a 20-minute ethnographic documentary publicly screened on campus with a post-screening Q&A
- Keywords: informal economy, livelihoods, internal labour migration, urban governance, community-engaged research, ethnographic film, policy communication, precarity, participatory research dissemination

Undergraduate Thesis, Public Attention Dynamics on Social Media During COVID-19 Jan 2023 — Jun 2023

Xi'an Jiaotong-Liverpool University

Supervised by Dr Gejun Huang

Suzhou, China

- Designed and executed a quantitative content analysis of 334 hashtags on social media, developing a 14-variable codebook with two independent coders and formally testing intercoder reliability and validity; applied chi-square and likelihood-ratio tests to identify statistically significant patterns in the dataset
- Keywords: quantitative content analysis, codebook design, intercoder reliability, public attention

Research Assistant, Students' Language Self-Regulation in English-Medium Higher Education Dec 2019

University of Oxford & Xi'an Jiaotong-Liverpool University

Supervised by Dr Sihan Zhou

Suzhou, China

- Contributed to a mixed-methods study on undergraduates' self-regulation in second-language learning within an English-medium higher-education environment
- Conducted semi-structured interviews with student participants and completed 20,000+ words of interview transcription, coding and organizing qualitative data to build the study corpus

ACADEMIC ENGAGEMENT

Panel Organizer & Chair, SEAA-SNU 2025 Conference "Shaping Futures: East Asia as Practice" Seoul, South Korea, Jul 2025

- Convened and organized the accepted four-paper panel "Entangled Futures: More-than-human Relations and Inter-species Encounters in China" for the joint conference of the Society for East Asian Anthropology (American Anthropological Association) and Seoul National University; authored a panel paper drawn from research master thesis research, presented in absentia by the co-chair

Policy Oriented Research Course Paper, Who Gets to Stay? Housing Affordability, Social Rental Regulation, and Policy Responses in Amsterdam Amsterdam, Spring 2024

- Authored a policy analysis proposal on Amsterdam's housing crisis as a course-based research project; positioned the analysis as a bid from the Netherlands Environmental Assessment Agency (PBL) to the Grond en Ontwikkeling (GeO), analysing the intersection of social housing regulation, affordability, and urban demographic change through Dutch housing policy frameworks including the 2015 Housing Act (Woningwet)

Summer School Fellow, Yunnan University Yunnan, China, Jun 2024 — Sep 2024

- Awarded a fully funded place through competitive selection for a three-month programme on multi-ethnic integration practices in Southern China; organized an internal seminar examining how inter-ethnic integration shapes human-nonhuman (multispecies) negotiation, extending research master thesis themes

EXTRACURRICULAR ACTIVITIES

Project Manager, DJI RoboMaster University Robotics Team Aug 2020 — Jan 2023

- Coordinated a 30+ member cross-national team across four technical sub-groups, managing an annual €20,000 budget, chairing weekly meetings, and serving as sole point of contact for on-site competition logistics

SKILLS AND HOBBIES

- **Qualitative Research:** NVivo; ethnography and participant observation; in-depth and semi-structured interviewing; qualitative coding and transcription; community access and trust-building in precarious field settings
- **Quantitative Research:** SPSS (advanced: regression, chi-square, likelihood-ratio tests, intercoder reliability and validity testing); quantitative content analysis; survey and codebook design
- **Media & Digital:** documentary production and editing; AI-assisted web development (designed and built personal academic website); research dissemination via film screening and public presentation
- **Languages:** English (C2), Mandarin (native), Dutch (A1-A2, actively improving)
- **Hobbies:** Kickboxing, Cooking, Analog Photography, Oil Pastel Art